PERIODICAL EXECUTION OF JOBS

Sometimes it may be required to execute certain Job or task on specific time. It may be not possible for any user to start or execute the job physically on that particular time due to other business requirements. Again if similar task need to be executed periodically on a regular interval, then the task becomes very hectic. Unix internally has solutions to handle this type of situations using utilities such as cron and at.

Crontab

The word 'crontab' in UNIX stand for chron(chronograph) table, or time table for Unix system .
The crontab is a special table where it is possible to specify commands and time or interval to execute the command once or repeatedly. Commands can be any executable programs, for example, a script can be written to take regular backup of all the required tables in database. A crontab instruction can be created to execute the script on the specified time. The cron daemon reads the table and executes the commands at the times specified.

Crontab Command Syntax

Syntax

```
# crontab  [-u user ]  -option [ file ]
```

Few of the options are explained in the table below:

Option	Description
-u	Name of the user whose crontab to be updated. If the option is not given then it updates the current user's crontab contents.
-l	Lists the current crontab contents
-e	Edit current crontab content using default editor
-i	Interactive update of crontab content

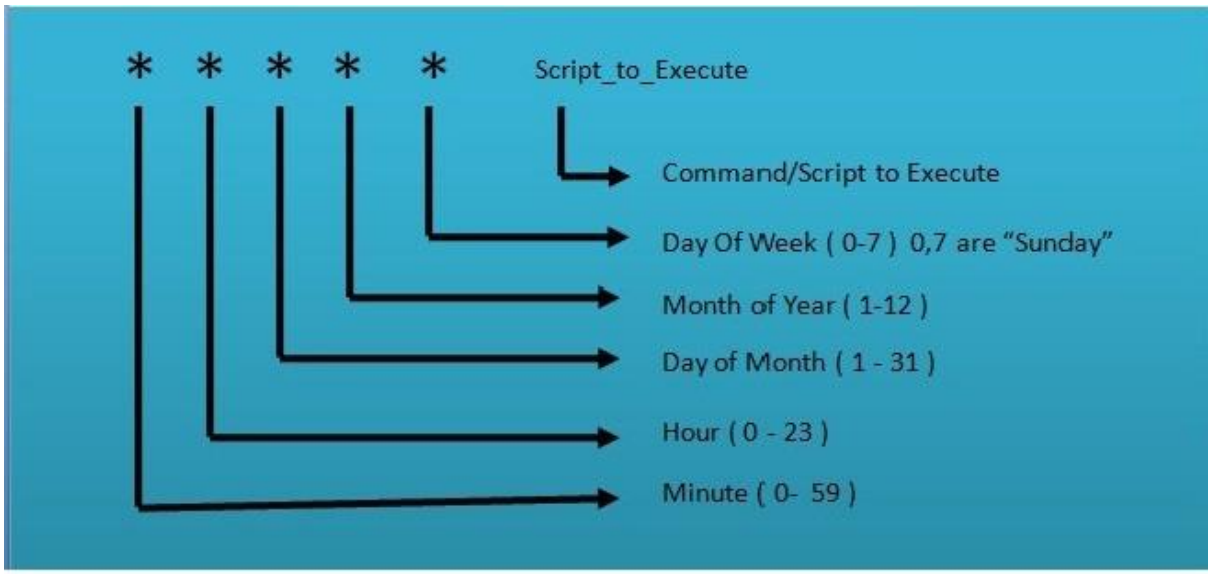
To list the existing crontab contents

```
[390119 @ INGNRILPORCL] $  crontab -l
* * * * * script.sh
```

Components of Crontab

The basic format of a crontab schedule consists of 6 fields, placed on a single line

and separated by spaces, formatted as follows:
The various fields and their utility are explained in the image below:





Example:

To executes an incremental backup shell script "takeBackup.sh" available in your home directory at 11:00 on every day the cron entry will be as below:

```
00 11 * * * ~/takeBackup.sh
```

To schedule the same job for every minute, the cron entry will be as follows:

```
* * * * * ~/takeBackup.sh
```